ACCOUNTING AND FINANCE - ACF768 (64787)

CORE ANALYSIS COCA-COLA LIMITED

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This report presents a trend analysis of the Coca-Cola Company's income statement and balance sheet for the years 2020 through 2023. The purpose is to evaluate the company’s financial performance using historical data and contextual explanations informed by internal company disclosures and external market conditions.

This report evaluates the Coca-Cola Company (2020–2023) to assess its suitability as an investment. The objective was to analyse Coca-Cola’s strategic and financial performance using a trend analysis of the income statement and balance sheet. I used the CORE framework (Context, Overview, Ratios, Evaluation) to interpret internal and external factors, alongside financial ratio analysis for profitability, efficiency, liquidity and solvency.

INTRODUCTION

Coca-Cola is a globally recognized billion dollar company, it is seen as the leader of the non-alcoholic beverage industry. It was founded on May 8th, 1886 by Dr. John Stith Pemberton and headquartered in Atlanta, Georgia. The company has grown to become one of the most valuable and iconic brands in the world, with operations in over 200 countries and a diverse portfolio of more than 500 brands.

This report analyses the financial performance of Coca-Cola to see if it will be a suitable investment choice for software solutions.The evaluation is grounded in a comprehensive analysis of strategic and financial performance, it covers the years 2021 to 2024. This report will be conducted by using Context, Overview, Ratios and Evaluation (CORE) framework (Moon and Bates, 1993) to analysis the internal and external environment of Coca-Cola using data found in the companies annual report.

CONTEXT(EXTERNAL)

POTER’S 5 FORCES

Porter’s Five Forces will be used to analyse and examine the external context of the company (Michael E. Porter, 1979) . It identifies five key elements that determine the intensity of competition and, therefore, the profitability potential of a business environment.

COMPETITIVE RIVARY

The competitive rivalry of Coca-Cola is relatively high. In 2022, Coca-Cola had a market share of roughly 46% (Beverage Digest, 2023), making it the most sort after beverage company in the world. The most notable rivalry for Coca cola is Pepsi, offering very similar products to Coca-Cola. Both Coca cola and Pepsi invest heavily in innovation, advertisements and promotional campaigns (The Coca-Cola Annual Report, 2024, p. 11). Internationally Coca-Cola only have a few competitors that can match them, but in some cases in other countries, competition is notable. For example, in Asian countries, Latin America and Africa, emerging brands disrupt Coca-Cola's market dominance (The Coca-Cola Annual Report, 2024, p. 11). Generally, it is more reasonable to compete with Coca cola on a small-scale, but it is also quite difficult, and with statistics showing that soda consumption is declining in previous years, as people are opting for healthier options, it intensifies the fight for market share (The Coca-Cola Annual Report, 2024, p. 20).

BARGAINING POWER OF SUPPLIERS

The bargaining power of suppliers is low to moderate. Coca-Cola, being a huge brand, has over the years gathered multiple suppliers, sourcing options, reducing dependency on one supplier. They also have long-term contracts with these companies, and Coca cola being a large company, has the power to negotiate bulk purchases (The Coca-Cola Annual Report, 2024, p. 18). They have also invested in bottling plants, reducing suppliers' influence (The Coca-Cola Company, 2025). Occasionally, global economic fluctuations can increase suppliers' power (The Coca-Cola Annual Report, 2024, p. 18).

BARGARNING POWER OF BUYERS

The bargaining power of buyers is low to moderate. Buyers of the brand include individual consumers, retailers and franchises. Coca-Cola has a huge consumer base and global recognition, which makes it a highly sort after brand (Beverage Digest, 2023; The Coca-Cola Company, 2025). And as a result, has strong brand loyalty. This drives consumers to purchase it despite available alternatives and low switching costs, making consumer power low. On the other hand, retailers and franchises such as supermarkets, Mac Donald's, cinemas and so on have some bargaining power because they buy in large quantity and can demand discounts or better terms (The Coca-Cola Annual Report, 2024, p. 17 - 20).

THREAT OF NEW ENTRANTS

The threat of new entry for Coca cola is moderate. It is the leading beverage brand having a global customer base and worldwide recognition and distribution, and a very prominent brand presence (Beverage Digest, 2023; The Coca-Cola Company, 2025). Coca-Cola has built a large brand recognition and strong customer loyalty with a brand value of over $106.45 billion in 2024 (Statista, 2024), making it difficult for new entrants to gain consumer trust and establish a comparable consumer base. Moreover, Coca cola has a massive distribution network reaching over 200 countries (The Coca-Cola Company, 2025), having contracts with restaurants, retailers and vending machines, creating a strong distribution channel. These are factors that make the barrier of entry high. Furthermore, consumers have low switching costs, making it easier to switch to other beverages. Additionally, the rise of health niches and smaller brands specializing in organic, gluten free, sugar free drinks have disrupted the market (Rigik, 2014, p. 22). Factors such as these lower the barrier of entry.

THREAT OF SUBUBSTITUTE PRODUCTS

Threat of substitution is high. In today’s world there are a countless number of beverages circulating the market, which makes for easy substitution. Factors like health concerns and low switching costs can affect consumer preference (The Coca-Cola Annual Report, 2024, p. 20). People are pulling back on sugary drinks because of obesity and diabetes risks also, with brands like Monster, Red Bull and Gatorade attracting the younger consumers (The Coca-Cola Annual Report, 2024, p. 20). Also, in places like Nigeria where fake Coca cola products have become an issue, people prefer to substitute for other products rather than exposing themselves to the risk of buying a counterfeit with ingredients that might be detrimental to their health (The Coca-Cola Annual Report, 2024, p. 21).

CONTEXT(INTERNAL)

Coca-Cola's business model has evolved from a single-product soft drink to a "total beverage company" spanning over 500 brands, yet its core activities still revolve around three pillars: concentrate production, brand marketing, and a franchised bottling system. Strategically, Coca-Cola pursues portfolio diversification, optimization, and sustainability leadership to drive growth amid shifting consumer preferences and regulatory pressures. In recent years, it has executed major changes including streamlining its brand portfolio, acquiring then scaling health and wellness brands, and setting aggressive environmental targets to future-proof its global beverage empire.

SWOT ANALYSIS

STRENGHTS	WEAKNESSES	OPPORTUNITIES	THREATS
Strong brand presence: Coca-Cola is undoubtedly one of the most globally recognized brands, According to Statista (2024) Coca-Cola ranks 15th on the most valuable global brands list . The brand's standing allows it to effortlessly retain customers across the globe.	Health related concerns: The growing health concerns over carbonated drinks across the years have caused a decline in their consumption (Rigik, 2014, p. 22). Coca-Cola, being a company whose brand consists mainly of carbonated drinks, has been affected by a decline in consumption.	Product diversification: With the growing shift towards healthier beverage options (Rigik, 2014, p. 22), Coca-Cola has an opportunity to expand further on its already existing organic, low sugar and functional beverage lines.	Competitive environment: The Coca-Cola Annual Report, (2024, p. 11) states that "PepsiCo, Inc. is a primary competitor. Other significant competitors include, but are not limited to, Nestlé S.A., Keurig Dr Pepper Inc., Danone S.A., Suntory Beverage & Food Limited, Unilever, AB InBev, Kirin Holdings, Heineken N.V., Diageo and Red Bull GmbH. We also compete against numerous regional and local companies and, increasingly, against smaller companies that are developing micro-brands and selling them directly to consumers through e-commerce retailers and other e-commerce platforms. In addition, in some markets, we compete against retailers that have developed their own store or private-label beverage brands"
Diverse portfolio: Coca-cola has a diverse portfolio with over 200+ brands (The Coca-Cola Company, 2025). This enables Coca-Cola to easily launch new products venture into new markets.	Digital & E-Commerce: Utilizing social media and direct-to-consumer platforms for engagement and sales expansion (bstrategyhub, 2019).	Emerging market growth: Coca-Cola can break into the market in countries with middle-class income through Strategic acquisitions and partnerships. They can go into partnership with local distributors in such countries to strengthen market saturation and penetration.	Environmental challenges: Poses as another weakness for Coca-Cola. Climate change and water scarcity are great threats to the company as it is heavily reliant on water for production. (Financial Times, 2024). The massive consumption of water for production has raised concerns, especially in water scarcity regions
Global reach: Coca-Cola is a global brand, with its presence in over 200 countries (The Coca-Cola Company, 2025).	Bottler dependencee: Coca-Cola is in partnership with over 200 bottling companies (The Coca-Cola Company, 2025; The Coca-Cola Annual Report, 2023, p. 22). Their global scale reliance on third party bottlers resulted in challenges in quality control, rapid market responsiveness and coordination.	Sustainability leadership: the Coca-Cola company (2024) states that it aims at 35-40% recycling content in packaging by 2035 and 70-75% container collection.	Legal challenges: Lawsuits have been issued against Coca-Cola for being unsustainable and using environmentally unfit packaging, which could result in fines (Break Free From Plastic, 2024; The Sun, 2025).

OVERVIEW

Income statement							
	2020	2021	% change	2022	% change	2023	% change
Revenue	33014	38655	17.09%	43004	11.25%	45754	6.39%
Operating profit	8997	10308	14.57%	10909	5.83%	11311	3.69%
Financial costs	1437	1597	11.13%	882	-44.77%	1527	73.13%
net profit	9804	7768	-20.77%	9571	23.21%	10703	11.83%
Cost of sales	13433	15357	14.32%	18000	17.21%	18520	2.89%

Balance sheet							
	2020	2021	% change	2022	% change	2023	% change
Current assets	19240	22545	17.18%	22591	0.20%	26732	18.33%
Non-current assets	68054	71809	5.52%	70172	-2.28%	70971	1.14%
current liabilities	14601	19950	36.63%	19724	-1.13%	23571	19.50%
non current liabilities	51411	49544	-3.63%	47213	-4.70%	46649	-1.19%
equity	21284	24860	16.80%	25826	3.89%	27480	6.40%

REVENUE GROWTH

Coca-Cola's revenue grew significantly from $33.01 billion in 2020 to $45.75 in 2023, reflecting an increase of nearly 39% over the four year period. The biggest increase happened between 2020 and 2021, with 17.09% increase. This was due to the company's recovery from the pandemic, which previously decreased sales as a result of businesses closing during lockdown (The Coca-Cola Company, 2022, p. 60; 2024, p. 61). the growth was also motivated by new product launch and expansion into global markets. However, from 2022 to 2023, growth slowed down to 6.4%, this was the effect of global inflation and changing consumer habits (The Coca-Cola Company, 2023).

PROFITABILITY

Operating profit rose steadily from $8.99 billion in 2020 to $11.31 billion in 2023, a 26% rise, driven by higher gross margins (from $19,581 billion to $27,234 billion) and disciplined SG&A control despite rising input costs (The Coca-Cola Company, 2022, pp. 59-60; 2024, p. 61), Though the growth rate slowed down after 2021. Net profit however, dropped by -20.77% in 2021 due to post pandemic supply chain challenges and higher financial costs but quickly rebounded in 2022 and 2023 (The Coca-Cola Company, 2022, p. 60; 2024, p. 61).

ASSETS

Coca-Cola's current assets increase from $19.24 billion in 2020 to $26.73 billion in 2023, indicating a growth of 18.33%. the growth was primarily driven by higher receivables and increased cash reserves (The Coca-Cola Company, 2024). non-current assets remained stable, fluctuating between $70 billion and $72 billion over the same period. It's stability suggests Coca-Cola followed a steady investment approach during this period. The asset growth aligns with Coca-Cola's modernization of supply chain, sustained investment in digital technologies and reflecting strategic initiative targeted at improving efficiency and innovation (Coca-Cola Company, 2024).

LIABILITIES

Current liabilities increased drastically from $14.60 billion in 2020 to $23.57 billion in 2023, in line with higher payable and short term borrowing. Non-current liabilities has declined over the four year period, from $51 billion in 2020 to $46.65 billion in 2023, showing a deliberate effort to reduce long-term debt exposure (The Coca-Cola Company, 2022, p. 63; 2024, p. 63).

EQUITY

Shareholder's equity increased from $21.28 billion in 2020 to $27.48 billion in 2023. this shows a rise of roughly $6.2 billion over the period, Indicating that the company's net worth has grown. The fundamental reason for this increase is strong retained earnings (The Coca-Cola Company, 2022, p. 64; 2024, p. 63).

ACCOUNTING POLICIES CHANGES

Coca-Cola did not adopt any major change in it's accounting policies between 2020 to 2023. the company maintained it's compliance to U.S GAAP, there was no indication of restatement or changes in accounting methods(The Coca-Cola Company, 2024).

RATIOS

Summary of ratios	2020	2021	2022	2023
profitability				
ROCE	**12.38%**	**13.85%**	**14.94%**	**15.26%**
Operating profit margin	**27.25%**	**26.67%**	**25.37%**	**24.72%**
return on assets	**11.23%**	**8.23%**	**10.32%**	**10.95%**
Efficiency				
Inventory Turnover days	**89**	**81**	**86**	**87**

receivable Turnover days	**35**	**33**	**30**	**27**
liquidity				
Current ratio	**1.32**	**1.13**	**1.15**	**1.13**
Quick ratio	**1.09**	**0.96**	**0.93**	**0.95**
Gearing Ratio				
interest cover	**6.26**	**6.45**	**12.37**	**7.41**
gering ratio	**71%**	**67%**	**65%**	**63%**
Investment potential ratio				
earning per share	**1.39**	**1.10**	**1.36**	**1.52**

EVALUATION

PROFITABILITY RATIO

The trajectory of the profitability ratios were mixed through the four years. Between 2020 and 2023 Coca-Cola became more efficient at generating profits from money invested in the business. Its ROCE increased steadily from 12.4% to 15.3%, showing strong performance. However, ROA fell in 2021 due to pandemic impact from closed business but recovered to 10.95% by 2023 (Coca-Cola, 2022, p. 60). Furthermore, operating profit margin shrank slightly each year, from 27.3% to 24.7% because of the rising costs of production and reinvestment in marketing to drive growth in key markets (Coca-Cola, 2024, p. 61). In comparison, Pepsi-Co's 2023 has an operating margin of 21.8% which falls below Coca-Cola’s 24.7%, illustrating Coke’s stronger cost leverage in its concentrate model.

EFFICIENCY RATIO

Coca-Cola's Inventory turnover days is mixed. The company became more efficient in taking their money from customers between 2020 and 2023. Receivables days improved steadily from 35 days in 2020 to just 27 days in 2023. however, inventory days fell to 81 days in 2021, then rose to 87 days in 2023. the 2021 fall was a result of fewer retail sales during the pandemic and tighter supply planning(Coca-Cola, 2022, pp. 62–63). Restaurants and cinemas fully reopened after the pandemic which resulted in the gradual increase of inventory days from 2022 - 2023 (Coca-Cola, 2024, p. 63). By 2023, Coca-Cola's 27 receivable days compared favorably to Pepsi-Co's 36 days, underlining Coke's disciplined cash collection.

LIQUIDITIY RATIO

Current ratio dropped from 1.32 in 2020 to a trough of 1.13 in 2021, then stayed at 1.14 through 2023. Quick ratio moved from 1.09 to 0.95 over the period. Since both ratios are sill above 1.0, it shows that Coca-Cola can cover its short trem payable but the drop shows it has fewer extra assets like cash or cash equivalents in comparison to what it owes in the short term. Between 2021 to 2022, Coca-Cola's liquidity ratio went down partly because it had more short term debt to pay and made a decision to buy back its own shares from investors (Coca-Cola, 2024, p. 64). In comparison Industry peers typically target a current ratio around 1.0 - 1.2; Coca-Cola's stable 1.13 remains in line with sector norms.

GEARING RATIO

Coca-Cola's gearing ratio fell from 71% to 63% from 2020 to 2023, which indicates the company relied less on debt over time. Its interest cover ratio spiked to 12.4x in 2022 before moderating to 7.4x in 2023, suggesting that the company kept its finances relatively safe and stable, earning enough to cover interest payments and using less debts. Gearing reduction was a results from the company paying off debts faster than it borrowed new ones, also keeping its profits instead of paying them off (Coca-Cola, 2024, p. 63). Robust profits in 2022 lead to a spike in investment cover, while the drop in 2023 was a result of Coca-Cola taking on more debt to fund strategic deals such as purchasing BodyArmor. By 2023, Pepsi-Co's gearing was 58% with interest cover 9x, placing Coca-Cola broadly in line with its largest competitor.

INVESTMENT RATIO

The trajectory of investment were mixed within the four years period, it fell from $1.39 in 2020 to $1.10 in 2021, then rose to $1.52 in 2023. this mixed trend shows that Coca-Cola's profits can be affected by rising costs and big changes in the economy, like the Covid-19 pandemic. 2021 EPS slump is a result of a fall in sales volume during the pandemic and restructuring costs (Coca-Cola, 2022, p. 60). The rebound in 2022 - 2023 motivated by raising product prices, sales of more profitable products and slightly reduced number of shares through buybacks (Coca-Cola, 2024, p. 61). Coca-Cola's EPS CAGR of 4.4% over 2020–23 slightly outpaced Pepsi-Co's 3.8%, underscoring Coke's stronger margin leverage in concentrate operations.

CONCLUSION AND RECOMMENDATION

Based on the CORE analysis, Software Solutions plc should consider investing in Coca-Cola as a minority shareholder. Coca-Cola has a strong and stable financial performance. It consists of a coherent revenue growth, solid profitability and a leading maker position. Its ratios show efficient use of capital and healthy core earnings. Although, the company carries moderate debt, it's interest cover remains high and it has sufficient liquidity. All these factors indicates it is a reasonably sound candidate for investment.

APPENDICES

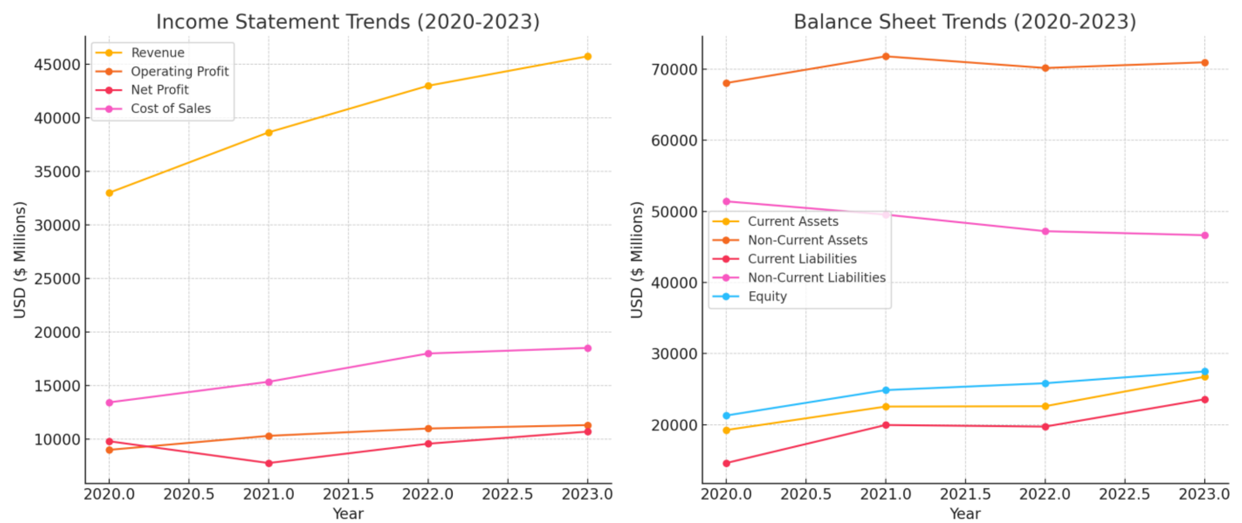
			2020	2021	2022	2023
Profitability						
Return on Capital Employed	Operating Profit (PBIT) x 100 Total Asset - current liabilities	Operating profit (Earnings from Operations)	**8,997**	**10,308**	**10,909**	**11,311**
		Total Assets	**87,294**	**94,354**	**92,763**	**97,703**
		Current liabilities	**14,601**	**19,950**	**19,724**	**23,571**
			12.38%	**13.85%**	**14.94%**	**15.26%**
Operating profit margin	Operating Profit x 100 Total Revenue	Operating profit (Earnings from Operations)	**8,997**	**10,308**	**10,909**	**11,311**
		Total Revenue	**33,014**	**38,655**	**43,004**	**45,754**

			27.3%	**26.7%**	**25.4%**	**24.7%**
Return on Assets	Net profit (profit for the year) x 100 / Total Assets	Net profit/loss	**9,804**	**7,768**	**9,571**	**10,703**
		Total Assets	**87,294**	**94,354**	**92,763**	**97,703**
			11.23%	**8.23%**	**10.32%**	**10.95%**
Liquidity Ratio						
Current Ratio (expressed as a ratio X:Y)	Current Asset / Current Liabilities	Current Asset	**19,240**	**22,545**	**22,591**	**26,732**
		Current Liabilities	**14,601**	**19,950**	**19,724**	**23,571**
			1.32	1.13	1.15	1.13
Quick Ratio (expressed as a ratio X:Y)	(Current Asset - inventories) / Current Liabilities	Current Asset	**19,240**	**22,545**	**22,591**	**26,732**
		Inventories	**3,266**	**3,414**	**4,233**	**4,424**
		Current Liabilities	**14,601**	**19,950**	**19,724**	**23,571**
			1.09	**0.96**	**0.93**	**0.95**
Efficiency Ratios						
		inventory	3,266	3,414	4,233	4,424

Inventory Turnover Days	Inventory x 365 days Cost of sales	Cost of sales	**13,433**	**15,357**	**18,000**	**18,520**
			365	**365**	**365**	**365**
			89	81	86	87
Receivables turnover days	Receivables x 365 days Total Revenue	Average receivables	**3144**	**3512**	**3487**	**3410**
		Total Revenue	**33,014**	**38,655**	**43,004**	**45,754**
			365	**366**	**367**	**368**
			35	33	30	27
Gearing Ratios						
Interest Coverage (Number of times)	Operating Profit Interest on Loan (Finance costs)	Operating profit	**8,997**	**10,308**	**10,909**	**11,311**
		Interest on loan	**1,437**	**1,597**	**882**	**1,527**
			6.26	6.45	12.37	7.41
Gearing Ratio (%)	Non-current liabilities x 100% Non-current	Non-current liabilities	**51,411**	**49,544**	**47,213**	**46,649**
		Total equity	**21,284**	**24,860**	**25,826**	**27,480**

	liabilities + total equity					
			71%	67%	65%	63%
Investment Ratio						
Earnings per Share	Net income (Profit for the Year) Number of ordinary shares	Net income	**9,804**	**7,768**	**9,571**	**10,703**
		Number of ordinary shares	**7,040**	**7,040**	**7,040**	**7,040**
			1.39	**1.10**	**1.36**	**1.52**

FIG1.1



DEFINITION OF TERMS

PROFITABILITY RATIOS: These ratios assess a business's ability to make money in relation to its assets, sales, or capital used. They demonstrate how well a business uses its resources to produce financial returns and how efficient it is at converting profits into revenue.

EFFICIENCY RATIOS: These ratios evaluate how well a business manages its assets and activities. The effectiveness and speed at which resources are converted into cash or income are the main topics of these ratios.

LIQUIDITY RATIOS: Liquidity ratios evaluate a company's ability to settle its short-term debts on time by using its current or near-cash assets. These are quite important for assessing one's present financial status.

INVESTMENT RATIOS: Also known as investor ratios, these metrics provide information on a company's market value and returns from the perspective of its shareholders. These ratios can be used to assess financial success in relation to share value and dividend policy.

GEARING RATIOS: Gearing ratios examine the relationship between debt and equity in a company's capital structure. The extent of the company's reliance on external funding and the financial risk associated with borrowing are reflected.

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